



Hum101 Assignment-01

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Section: 11

The Role of Ancient History and Mythology in Understanding Human Civilization

The study of ancient history is not merely committing to memory the dates or names of former kings. It is all about knowing the human experience through time. The ancient history gives us an insight into the way early societies believed, lead their lives, and made art, exercised religion, and how they solved problems. It unveils the origin of the modern cultures, values, and practices.

Ancient history is helpful because it allows us to understand human continuity. The ancient Egyptian religion defined the practice of governance as well as religion where the Pharaoh was viewed as a political and divine leader who believed in an after-world (Eliade, 1991). These themes are universal that, in spite of technological changes, the fundamentals of human life cannot be changed. Their progress and errors help us to comprehend our society more. The ancient Greeks, tested democracy, but women and slaves were not allowed to take part in it. This inconsistency asks us to consider how well we have achieved equality and justice. On the same note, the relationship between religion and governance is emphasized by the Indian kingdoms, where the kings were regarded as divine authorities in which they had to enforce dharma (Tuck, 2017). As we compare these ancient concepts with the contemporary systems, we would better understand the success and failures in our political systems. The history of other civilizations helps us realize how other cultures perceived life, the right and the wrong and the truth. This Chinese mandate of heaven condoned the divine right to leadership by the emperor because of the focus on morals (Gunkel, 2012). These ancient concepts were the root cause of political systems that considered leadership as a divine responsibility which shaped the political structures over centuries.

Myths are a key to the ancient history. It cannot be considered simply fiction since they provide actual historical facts as well as social values expressed in symbols. As an illustration, there are numerous cultures that have flood myths probably due to the recollection of actual floods. One of the flood stories in the Epic of Gilgamesh is supposed to have been based on the experience of floods in ancient Mesopotamia, though it is mythological (Gunkel, 2012). Such myths are of a cultural nature and they consist of stores of old memories about natural disasters, wars, and migrations which would otherwise not have been documented. Besides having historical significance, myths offer moral and social lessons concerning the civilizations of the ancient times. The concept of the Egyptian myth of Osiris in which the Pharaoh is presented as a deity supports the notion that leaders had a duty of ensuring that order existed both in the physical world and the world of the gods (Eliade, 1991). This is the opinion that the kingship was divine and this enabled the stability in the society to explore the relationship between religion and government. In the same way, the Iliad and the Odyssey say the same values of honor and fate, as well as the impact of hubris, which were dominant in Greek culture (Johnston, 2018). Not only do these myths provide insight into the morals of the earlier times, but they also maintain the social as well as the political systems of the era. Myths were essential in preserving cultural memory as well. As highlighted by the article about the main components of civilization published by National Geographic, the key

to the development of the early society were the central role of agriculture, social organization, and trade (Key Components of Civilization, 2025) These stories played a crucial role in imparting the values and moral teachings that ruled the day to day activities.

Finally, studying ancient history allows us to have a better insight of human experience by giving information on how ancient times were governed, how they interacted and evolved. Although not necessarily true, myths tell cultural truths, which supply the values, beliefs, and the social structure of past civilizations. Alternatively, it is by examining historical documents and legends that we have a better insight into the roots of our present, and it enables us to examine our world, and see how important human experience in the past has been over time.

Reference

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